

they so formidably displeased the citizens, that he had finished by painting no more.

He boasted of having painted a bath-room for Madame la Maréchale d'Ancre, and mourned over this chamber having been burnt at the time of the maréchal's disaster.

Croupole, in his character of a compatriot, was indulgent towards Pittirino, which was the name of the artist. Perhaps he had seen the famous pictures of the bath-room. Be this as it may, he held in such esteem, we may say in such friendship, the famous Pittirino, that he took him in his own house.

Pittirino, grateful, and fed with macaroni, set about propagating the reputation of this national dish, and from the time of its founder, he had rendered, with his indefatigable tongue, signal services to the house of Croupole.

As he grew old he attached himself to the son as he had done to the father, and by degrees became a kind of over-looker of a house in which his remarkable integrity, his acknowledged sobriety, and a thousand other virtues useless to enumerate, gave him an eternal place by the fireside, with a right of inspection over the domestics. Besides this, it was he who tasted the macaroni, to maintain the pure flavour of the ancient tradition; and it must be allowed that he never permitted a grain of pepper too much, or an atom of parmesan too little. His joy was at its height on that day when called upon to share the secret of Croupole the younger, and to paint the famous sign.

He was seen at once rummaging with ardour in an old box, in which he found some brushes, a little gnawed by the rats, but still passable; some linseed-oil in a bottle, and a palette which had formerly belonged to Bronzino, that *dieu de la pittoure*, as the ultramontane artist, in his ever young enthusiasm, always called him.

Pittirino was puffed up with all the joy of a rehabilitation.

He did as Raphael had done—he changed his style, and painted, in the fashion of Albani, two goddesses rather than two queens. These illustrious ladies appeared so lovely on the sign,—they presented to the astonished eyes such an assemblage of lilies and roses, the enchanting result of the changes of style in Pittirino—they assumed the poses of sirens so Anacreontically—that the principal *échevin*, when admitted to view this capital piece in the *salle* of Croupole, at once declared that these ladies were too handsome, of too animated a beauty, to figure as a sign in the eyes of passers-by.

To Pittirino he added, 'His royal highness, Monsieur, who often comes into our city, will not be much pleased to see his illustrious mother so slightly clothed, and he will send you to the *oubliettes* of the state; for, remember, the heart of that glorious prince is not always tender. You must efface either the two sirens or the legend, without which I forbid the exhibition of the sign. I say this for your sake, Master Croupole, as well for yours, *Signor Pittirino*.'

What answer could be made to this? It was necessary to thank the *échevin* for his kindness, which Croupole did. But Pittirino remained downcast and said he felt assured of what was about to happen.

The visitor was scarcely gone when Croupole, crossing his arms, said: 'Well, master, what is to be done?'

'We must efface the legend,' said Pittirino, in a melancholy tone. 'I have some excellent ivory-black; it will be done in a moment, and we will replace the Medici by the nymphs or the sirens, whichever you prefer.'

'No,' said Croupole, 'the will of my father must be carried out. My father considered—'

'He considered the figures of the most importance,' said Pittirino.

'He thought most of the legend,' said Croupole.

'The proof of the importance in which he held the figures,' said Pittirino, 'is that he desired they should be likenesses, and they are so.'

'Yes; but if they had not been so, who would have recognized them without the legend? At the present day even, when the memory of the Blaisois begins to be faint with regard to these two celebrated persons, who would recognize Catherine and Mary without the words "To the Medici"?'

'But the figures?' said Pittirino, in despair; for he felt that young Croupole was right. 'I should not like to lose the fruit of my labour.'

'And I should not wish you to be thrown into prison, and myself into the *oubliettes*.'

'Let us efface "Medici",' said Pittirino, supplicatingly.

'No,' replied Croupole, firmly. 'I have got an idea, a sublime idea—your picture shall appear, and my legend likewise. Does not "Medici" mean doctor, or physician, in Italian?'

'Yes, in the plural.'

‘Well, then, you shall order another sign-frame of the smith; you shall paint six physicians, and write underneath “Aux Medici” which makes a very pretty play upon words.’

‘Six physicians! impossible! And the composition?’ cried Pittirino.

‘That is your business—but so it shall be—I insist upon it—it must be so—my macaroni is burning.’

This reasoning was peremptory—Pittirino obeyed. He composed the sign of six physicians, with the legend; the échevin applauded and authorized it.

The sign produced an extravagant success in the city, which proves that poetry has always been in the wrong, before citizens, as Pittirino said.

Cropole, to make amends to his painter-in-ordinary, hung up the nymphs of the preceding sign in his bedroom, which made Madame Cropole blush every time she looked at it, when she was undressing at night.

This is the way in which the pointed-gable house got a sign; and this is how the hostelry of the Medici, making a fortune, was found to be enlarged by a quarter, as we have described. And this is how there was at Blois a hostelry of that name, and had for a painter-in-ordinary Master Pittirino.

established a little hostelry, in which was fabricated a macaroni so delicious that people came from miles round to fetch it or eat it.

So famous had the house become for it, that when Mary de Medici was a prisoner, as we know, in the castle of Blois, she once sent for some.

It was precisely on the day she had escaped by the famous window. The dish of macaroni was left upon the table, only just tasted by the royal mouth.

This double favour, of a strangulation and a macaroni, conferred upon the triangular house, gave poor Cropoli a fancy to grace his hostelry with a pompous title. But his quality of an Italian was no recommendation in these times, and his small, well-concealed fortune forbade attracting too much attention.

When he found himself about to die, which happened in 1643, just after the death of Louis XIII, he called to him his son, a young cook of great promise, and with tears in his eyes, he recommended him to preserve carefully the secret of the macaroni, to Frenchify his name, and at length, when the political horizon should be cleared from the clouds which obscured it—this was practised then as in our day, to order of the nearest smith a handsome sign, upon which a famous painter, whom he named, should design two queens’ portraits, with these words as a legend: ‘TO THE MEDICI.’

The worthy Cropoli, after these recommendations, had only sufficient time to point out to his young successor a chimney, under the slab of which he had hidden a thousand ten-franc pieces, and then expired.

Cropoli the younger, like a man of good heart, supported the loss with resignation, and the gain without insolence. He began by accustoming the public to sound the final i of his name so little, that by the aid of general complaisance, he was soon called nothing but M. Cropole, which is quite a French name. He then married, having had in his eye a little French girl, from whose parents he extorted a reasonable dowry by showing them what there was beneath the slab of the chimney.

These two points accomplished, he went in search of the painter who was to paint the sign; and he was soon found. He was an old Italian, a rival of the Raphaels and the Caracci, but an unfortunate rival. He said he was of the Venetian school, doubtless from his fondness for colour. His works, of which he had never sold one, attracted the eye at a distance of a hundred paces; but

beyond the Loire, to gather green boughs and field-flowers. The whole city, not to be behind in this luxury of cleanliness, assumed its best toilette with the help of brushes, brooms, and water. The gutters of the upper town, swollen by these continued ablutions, became rivers at the bottom of the city, and the pavement, generally very muddy, it must be allowed, took a clean face, and absolutely shone in the friendly rays of the sun.

Next the music was to be provided; drawers were emptied; the shop-keepers did a glorious trade in wax, ribbons, and sword-knots; housekeepers laid in stores of bread, meat, and spices. Already numbers of the citizens whose houses were furnished as if for a siege, having nothing more to do, donned their festive clothes, and directed their course towards the city gate, in order to be the first to signal or see the cortège. They knew very well that the king would not arrive before night, perhaps not before the next morning. Yet what is expectation but a kind of folly, and what is that folly but an excess of hope?

In the lower city, at scarcely a hundred paces from the Castle of the States, between the mall and the castle, in a sufficiently handsome street, then called the Rue Vieille, and which must, in fact, have been very old, stood a venerable edifice, with pointed gables, of squat but large dimensions, ornamented with three windows looking into the street on the first floor, with two in the second, and with a little *œil de boeuf* in the third.

On the sides of this triangle had recently been constructed a parallelogram of considerable size, which encroached upon the street remorselessly, according to the familiar uses of the building of that period. The street was narrowed by a quarter by it, but then the house was enlarged by a half; and was not that a sufficient compensation?

Tradition said that this house with the pointed gables was inhabited, in the time of Henry III, by a councillor of state whom Queen Catherine came, some say to visit, and others to strangle. However that may be, the good lady must have stepped with a circumspect foot over the threshold of this building.

After the councillor had died—whether by strangulation or naturally is of no consequence—the house had been sold, then abandoned, and lastly isolated from the other houses of the street. Towards the middle of the reign of Louis XIII only, an Italian named Cropoli, escaped from the kitchens of the Maréchal d'Ancre, came and took possession of this house. There he

## Chapter VI

### The Unknown



Louis founded and recommended by its sign, the hostelry of Master Cropole held its way steadily on towards a solid prosperity. It was not an immense fortune that Cropole had in perspective; but he might hope to double the thousand louis d'or left by his father, to make another thousand louis by the sale of his house and stock, and at length to live happily like a retired citizen.

Cropole was anxious for gain, and was half-crazy with joy at the news of the arrival of Louis XIV.

Himself, his wife, Pittirino, and two cooks, immediately laid hands upon all the inhabitants of the dove-cote, the poultry-yard, and the rabbit-hutches; so that as many lamentations and cries resounded in the yards of the hostelry of the Medici as were formerly heard in Rama.

Cropole had, at the time, but one single traveller in his house.

This was a man of scarcely thirty years of age, handsome, tall, austere, or rather melancholy, in all his gestures and looks.

He was dressed in black velvet with jet trimmings; a white collar, as plain as that of the severest Puritan, set off the whiteness of his youthful neck; a small dark-coloured moustache scarcely covered his curled, disdainful lip.

He spoke to people looking them full in the face, without affectation, it is true, but without scruple; so that the brilliancy of his black eyes became so insupportable, that more than one look had sunk beneath his, like the weaker sword in a single combat.

At this time, in which men, all created equal by God, were divided, thanks to prejudices, into two distinct castes, the gentlemen and the commoner, as they are really divided into two races, the black and the white,—at this time,

we say, he whose portrait we have just sketched could not fail of being taken for a gentleman, and of the best class. To ascertain this, there was no necessity to consult anything but his hands, long, slender, and white, of which every muscle, every vein, became apparent through the skin at the least movement, and eloquently spoke of good descent.

This gentleman, then, had arrived alone at Cropole's house. He had taken, without hesitation, without reflection even, the principal apartment which the hôtelier had pointed out to him with a rapacious aim, very praiseworthy, some will say, very reprehensible will say others, if they admit that Cropole was a physiognomist, and judged people at first sight.

This apartment was that which composed the whole front of the ancient triangular house; a large salon, lighted by two windows on the first stage, a small chamber by the side of it, and another above it.

Now, from the time he had arrived, this gentleman had scarcely touched any repast that had been served up to him in his chamber. He had spoken but two words to the host, to warn him that a traveller of the name of Parry would arrive, and to desire that, when he did, he should be shown up to him immediately.

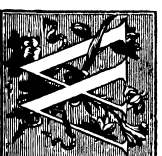
He afterwards preserved so profound a silence, that Cropole was almost offended, so much did he prefer people who were good company.

This gentleman had risen early the morning of the day on which this history begins, and had placed himself at the window of his salon, seated upon the ledge, and leaning upon the rail of the balcony, gazing sadly but persistently on both sides of the street, watching, no doubt, for the arrival of the traveller he had mentioned to the host.

In this way he had seen the little cortège of Monsieur return from hunting, then had again partaken of the profound tranquillity of the street, absorbed in his own expectations.

All at once the movement of the crowd going to the meadows, couriers setting out, washers of pavement, purveyors of the royal household, gabbling, scampering shop-boys, chariots in motion, hair-dressers on the run, and pages toiling along, this tumult and bustle had surprised him, but without losing any of that impassible and supreme majesty which gives to the eagle and the lion that serene and contemptuous glance amidst the hurrahs and shouts of hunters or the curious.

## Chapter V In Which Something Will be Said of Cropoli



MUST the Comte de la Fère with Raoul visit the new buildings he has erected, and the new horses he has bought, with the reader's permission we will lead him back to the city of Blois, and make him a witness of the unaccustomed activity which pervades that city.

It was in the hotels that the surprise of the news brought by Raoul was most sensibly felt.

In fact, the king and the court at Blois, that is to say, a hundred horsemen, ten carriages, two hundred horses, as many lackeys as masters—where was this crowd to be housed? Where were to be lodged all the gentry of the neighbourhood, who would gather in two or three hours after the news had enlarged the circle of its report, like the increasing circumferences produced by a stone thrown into a placid lake?

Blois, as peaceful in the morning, as we have seen, as the calmest lake in the world, at the announcement of the royal arrival, was suddenly filled with the tumult and buzzing of a swarm of bees.

All the servants of the castle, under the inspection of the officers, were sent into the city in quest of provisions, and ten horsemen were dispatched to the preserves of Chambord to seek for game, to the fisheries of Beuvron for fish, and to the gardens of Cheverny for fruits and flowers.

Precious tapestries, and lustres with great gilt chains, were drawn from the cupboards; an army of the poor were engaged in sweeping the courts and washing the stone fronts, whilst their wives went in droves to the meadows

'Now, if you please, we will go into the garden, Raoul. I will show you the new lodging I have had prepared for you during your leave of absence; and whilst examining the last winter's plantations, and two saddle-horses I have just acquired, you will give me all the news of our friends in Paris.'

The comte closed his manuscript, took the young man's arm, and went out into the gardens with him.

Grimaud looked at Raoul with a melancholy air as the young man passed out; observing that his head nearly touched the traverse of the doorway, stroking his white royale, he slowly murmured:—'How he has grown!'

Soon the cries of the victims slaughtered in the poultry-yard, the hasty steps of Madame Cropole up that little wooden staircase, so narrow and so echoing; the bounding pace of Pitrino, who only that morning was smoking at the door with all the phlegm of a Dutchman; all this communicated something like surprise and agitation to the traveller.

As he was rising to make inquiries, the door of his chamber opened. The unknown concluded they were about to introduce the impatiently expected traveller, and made three precipitate steps to meet him.

But, instead of the person he expected, it was Master Cropole who appeared, and behind him, in the half-dark staircase, the pleasant face of Madame Cropole, rendered trivial by curiosity. She only gave one furtive glance at the handsome gentleman, and disappeared.

Cropole advanced, cap in hand, rather bent than bowing.

A gesture of the unknown interrogated him, without a word being pronounced.

'Monsieur,' said Cropole, 'I come to ask how—what ought I to say: your lordship, monsieur le comte, or monsieur le marquis?'

'Say monsieur, and speak quickly,' replied the unknown, with that haughty accent which admits of neither discussion nor reply.

'I came, then, to inquire how monsieur had passed the night, and if monsieur intended to keep this apartment?'

'Yes.'

'Monsieur, something has happened upon which we could not reckon.'

'What?'

'His majesty Louis XIV will enter our city to-day, and will remain here one day, perhaps two.'

Great astonishment was painted on the countenance of the unknown.

'The King of France is coming to Blois?'

'He is on the road, monsieur.'

'Then there is the stronger reason for my remaining,' said the unknown.

'Very well; but will monsieur keep all the apartments?'

'I do not understand you. Why should I require less to-day than yesterday?'

'Because, monsieur, your lordship will permit me to say, yesterday I did not think proper, when you chose your lodging, to fix any price that might have made your lordship believe that I prejudged your resources; whilst to-day—'

The unknown coloured; the idea at once struck him that he was supposed to be poor, and was being insulted.

'Whilst to-day,' replied he, coldly, 'you do not prejudice.'

'Monsieur, I am a well-meaning man, thank God! and simple hôtelier as I am, there is in me the blood of a gentleman. My father was a servant and officer of the late Maréchal d'Ancre. God rest his soul!

'I do not contest that point with you; I only wish to know, and that quickly, to what your questions tend?'

'You are too reasonable, monsieur, not to comprehend that our city is small, that the court is about to invade it, that the houses will be overflowing with inhabitants, and that lodgings will consequently obtain considerable prices.'

Again the unknown coloured. 'Name your terms,' said he.

'I name them with scruple, monsieur, because I seek an honest gain, and that I wish to carry on my business without being uncivil or extravagant in my demands. Now the room you occupy is considerable, and you are alone.'

'That is my business.'

'Oh! certainly. I do not mean to turn monsieur out.'

The blood rushed to the temples of the unknown; he darted at poor Cropole, the descendant of one of the officers of the Maréchal d'Ancre, a glance that would have crushed him down to beneath that famous chimney-slab, if Cropole had not been nailed to the spot by the question of his own proper interests.

'Do you desire me to go?' said he. 'Explain yourself—but quickly.'

'Monsieur, monsieur, you do not understand me. It is very critical—I know—that which I am doing. I express myself badly, or perhaps, as monsieur is a foreigner, which I perceive by his accent—'

In fact, the unknown spoke with that impetuosity which is the principal character of English accentuation, even among men who speak the French language with the greatest purity.

'As monsieur is a foreigner, I say, it is perhaps he who does not catch my exact meaning. I wish for monsieur to give up one or two of the apartments he occupies, which would diminish his expenses and ease my conscience. Indeed, it is hard to increase unreasonably the price of the chambers, when one has had the honour to let them at a reasonable price.'

'How much does the hire amount to since yesterday?'

mission, that chance brought us together. I have had the honour of paying my respects to her.'

'But what do you call the chance that led you into the presence of Mademoiselle de La Vallière?'

'Mademoiselle de Montalais, monsieur.'

'And who is Mademoiselle de Montalais?'

'A young lady I did not know before, whom I had never seen. She is maid of honour to Madame.'

'Monsieur le vicomte, I will push my interrogatory no further, and reproach myself with having carried it so far. I had desired you to avoid Mademoiselle de La Vallière, and not to see her without my permission. Oh, I am quite sure you have told me the truth, and that you took no measures to approach her. Chance has done me this injury; I do not accuse you of it. I will be content, then, with what I formerly said to you concerning this young lady. I do not reproach her with anything—God is my witness! only it is not my intention or wish that you should frequent her place of residence. I beg you once more, my dear Raoul, to understand that.'

It was plain the limpid eyes of Raoul were troubled at this speech.

'Now, my friend,' said the comte, with his soft smile, and in his customary tone, 'let us talk of other matters. You are returning, perhaps, to your duty?'

'No, monsieur, I have no duty for to-day, except the pleasure of remaining with you. The prince kindly appointed me no other: which was so much in accord with my wish.'

'Is the king well?'

'Perfectly.'

'And monsieur le prince also?'

'As usual, monsieur.'

The comte forgot to inquire after Mazarin; that was an old habit.

'Well, Raoul, since you are entirely mine, I will give up my whole day to you. Embrace me—again, again! You are at home, vicomte! Ah, there is our old Grimaud! Come in, Grimaud: monsieur le vicomte is desirous of embracing you likewise.'

The good old man did not require to be twice told; he rushed in with open arms, Raoul meeting him half-way.

'Thank God, monsieur,' replied Raoul, calming himself by degrees, 'nothing has happened but what is fortunate. The king is going to be married, as I had the honour of informing you in my last letter, and, on his way to Spain, he will pass through Blois.'

'To pay a visit to Monsieur?'

'Yes, monsieur le comte. So, fearing to find him unprepared, or wishing to be particularly polite to him, monsieur le prince sent me forward to have the lodgings ready.'

'You have seen Monsieur?' asked the comte, eagerly.

'I have had that honour.'

'At the castle?'

'Yes, monsieur,' replied Raoul, casting down his eyes, because, no doubt, he had felt there was something more than curiosity in the comte's inquiries.

'Ah, indeed, vicomte? Accept my compliments thereupon.'

Raoul bowed.

'But you have seen some one else at Blois?'

'Monsieur, I saw her royal highness, Madame.'

'That's very well: but it is not Madame that I mean.'

Raoul coloured deeply, but made no reply.

'You do not appear to understand me, monsieur le vicomte,' persisted M. de la Fère, without accenting his words more strongly, but with a rather severer look.

'I understand you quite plainly, monsieur,' replied Raoul, 'and if I hesitate a little in my reply, you are well assured I am not seeking for a falsehood.'

'No, you cannot tell a lie; and that makes me so astonished you should be so long in saying yes or no.'

'I cannot answer you without understanding you very well; and if I have understood you, you will take my first words in ill part. You will be displeased, no doubt, monsieur le comte, because I have seen—'

'Mademoiselle de La Vallière—have you not?'

'It was of her you meant to speak, I know very well, monsieur,' said Raoul, with inexpressible sweetness.

'And I asked you if you have seen her.'

'Monsieur, I was ignorant, when I entered the castle, that Mademoiselle de La Vallière was there; it was only on my return, after I had performed my

'Monsieur, to one louis, with refreshments and the charge for the horse.'

'Very well, and that of to-day?'

'Ah! there is the difficulty. This is the day of the king's arrival; if the court comes to sleep here, the charge of the day is reckoned. From that it results that three chambers, at two louis each, make six louis. Two louis, monsieur, are not much; but six louis make a great deal.'

The unknown, from red, as we have seen him, became very pale.

He drew from his pocket, with heroic bravery, a purse embroidered with a coat-of-arms, which he carefully concealed in the hollow of his hand. This purse was of a thinness, a flabbiness, a hollowness, which did not escape the eye of Cropole.

The unknown emptied the purse into his hand. It contained three double louis, which amounted to the six louis demanded by the host.

But it was seven that Cropole had required.

He looked, therefore, at the unknown, as much as to say, 'And then?'

'There remains one louis, does there not, master hôtelier?'

'Yes, monsieur, but—'

The unknown plunged his hand into the pocket of his *haut-de-chausses*, and emptied it. It contained a small pocket-book, a gold key, and some silver. With this change, he made up a louis.

'Thank you, monsieur,' said Cropole. 'It now only remains for me to ask whether monsieur intends to occupy his apartments to-morrow, in which case I will reserve them for him; whereas, if monsieur does not mean to do so, I will promise them to some of the king's people who are coming.'

'That is but right,' said the unknown, after a long silence; 'but as I have no more money, as you have seen, and as I yet must retain the apartments, you must either sell this diamond in the city, or hold it in pledge.'

Cropole looked at the diamond so long, that the unknown said, hastily:

'I prefer your selling it, monsieur; for it is worth three hundred pistoles. A Jew—are there any Jews in Blois?—would give you two hundred or a hundred and fifty for it—take whatever may be offered for it, if it be no more than the price of your lodging. Begone!'

'Oh! monsieur,' replied Cropole, ashamed of the sudden inferiority which the unknown reflected upon him by this noble and disinterested confidence, as well as by the unalterable patience opposed to so many suspicions and evasions.

‘Oh, monsieur, I hope people are not so dishonest at Blois as you seem to think; and that the diamond, being worth what you say—’

The unknown here again darted at Cropole one of his withering glances.

‘I really do not understand diamonds, monsieur, I assure you,’ cried he.

‘But the jewelers do: ask them,’ said the unknown. ‘Now I believe our accounts are settled, are they not, monsieur l’hôte?’

‘Yes, monsieur, and to my profound regret; for I fear I have offended monsieur.’

‘Not at all!’ replied the unknown, with ineffable majesty.

‘Or have appeared to be extortionate with a noble traveller. Consider, monsieur, the peculiarity of the case.’

‘Say no more about it, I desire; and leave me to myself.’

Cropole bowed profoundly, and left the room with a stupefied air, which announced that he had a good heart, and felt genuine remorse.

The unknown himself shut the door after him, and, when left alone, looked mournfully at the bottom of the purse, from which he had taken a small silken bag containing the diamond, his last resource.

He dwelt likewise upon the emptiness of his pockets, turned over the papers in his pocket-book, and convinced himself of the state of absolute destitution in which he was about to be plunged.

He raised his eyes towards heaven, with a sublime emotion of despairing calmness, brushed off with his hand some drops of sweat which trickled over his noble brow, and then cast down upon the earth a look which just before had been impressed with almost divine majesty.

That the storm had passed far from him, perhaps he had prayed in the bottom of his soul.

He drew near to the window, resumed his place in the balcony, and remained there, motionless, annihilated, dead, till the moment when, the heavens beginning to darken, the first flambeaux traversed the enlivened street, and gave the signal for illumination to all the windows of the city.

Raoul found the garden-gate open, and rode straight in, without regarding the long arms, raised in anger, of an old man dressed in a jacket of violet-coloured wool, and a large cap of faded velvet.

The old man, who was weeding with his hands a bed of dwarf roses and marguerites, was indignant at seeing a horse thus traversing his sanded and nicely-raked walks. He even ventured a vigorous ‘Humph!’ which made the cavalier turn round. Then there was a change of scene; for no sooner had he caught sight of Raoul’s face, than the old man sprang up and set off in the direction of the house, amidst interrupted growlings, which appeared to be paroxysms of wild delight.

When arrived at the stables, Raoul gave his horse to a little lackey, and sprang up the perron with an ardour that would have delighted the heart of his father.

He crossed the ante-chamber, the dining-room, and the salon, without meeting any one; at length, on reaching the door of M. de la Fère’s apartment, he rapped impatiently, and entered almost without waiting for the word ‘Enter!’ which was vouchsafed him by a voice at once sweet and serious. The comte was seated at a table covered with papers and books; he was still the noble, handsome gentleman of former days, but time had given to this nobleness and beauty a more solemn and distinct character. A brow white and void of wrinkles, beneath his long hair, now more white than black; an eye piercing and mild, under the lids of a young man; his moustache, fine but slightly grizzled, waved over lips of a pure and delicate model, as if they had never been curled by mortal passions; a form straight and supple; an irreproachable but thin hand—this was what remained of the illustrious gentleman whom so many illustrious mouths had praised under the name of Athos. He was engaged in correcting the pages of a manuscript book, entirely filled by his own hand.

Raoul seized his father by the shoulders, by the neck, as he could, and embraced him so tenderly and so rapidly, that the comte had neither strength nor time to disengage himself, or to overcome his paternal emotions.

‘What! you here, Raoul—you! Is it possible?’ said he.

‘Oh, monsieur, monsieur, what joy to see you once again!’

‘But you don’t answer me, vicomte. Have you leave of absence, or has some misfortune happened at Paris?’